Crime-Scene Documentation and Evidence Custody

CRIMINOLOGIST · criminal-justice-foundations · BoardPrep lesson v2

Official examination scope

The PRC enhanced Criminology TOS defines licensure competencies; consult its current annex for exact boundaries. This lesson teaches scene documentation, evidence preservation, and custody records using NIJ guidance. It does not estimate item frequency or replace applicable Philippine law and agency procedures.

Learning objectives

- Sequence scene access control, observation, documentation, and evidence collection without
- losing context.
- Trace an item through identification, condition, packaging, seal, authorized examination, and
- transfer records.
- Describe a documentation or custody gap accurately without inferring alteration or legal
- admissibility from the record alone.

1. Secure, observe, and document

Protect people first and control access under the applicable agency procedures. Record the scene condition on arrival before avoidable changes occur. Use notes, photographs, measurements, and sketches to preserve different details and relationships; identify the scale and location when the method requires them. Separate what was directly observed from later interpretation. Do not treat a single photograph or a list of collected objects as a complete record of scene context.

2. Preserve context before collection

Document an item in its surrounding context before collection when circumstances allow. Record its location and relationship to other traces, then use the approved collection method for that item. If weather or loss creates urgency, protect vulnerable material promptly and document the sequence while parallel tasks are assigned where staffing permits. Packaging, preservation, and collection details depend on the evidence type, laboratory requirements, safety, and agency protocol.

3. Maintain custody continuity

Give each item a unique identifier and record its description, condition, recovery location, date and time, collector, package, and seal. For each transfer, record who released and received it, when, and for what purpose. Follow secure storage and laboratory rules. If an authorized examination opens a package, record the event and replacement seal under policy; do not reconstruct undocumented details from memory as though they were contemporaneous observations.

4. Review gaps without overclaiming

A missing transfer entry, broken seal, or incomplete resealing record is a traceability discrepancy that needs review. The record alone does not identify who caused a gap or prove that the item changed. Preserve the original record, compare authorized laboratory notes and receipts, seek an accountable explanation, and document unresolved limits. This instructional method does not decide Philippine admissibility, criminal liability, or the legal effect of any particular defect.

Review an incomplete reseal record

Question: A laboratory log says an exhibit was opened for testing and resealed, but the replacement seal has no initials or date. What can the reviewer conclude?
1. Identify the missing initials and date as a documentation gap.

2. Check authorized laboratory records, transfer receipts, and the examiner's account for an explanation.
3. Do not call the gap tampering unless independent evidence supports that conclusion.
Answer: The resealing event is insufficiently documented and requires explanation and corroboration.
Check: The conclusion preserves the evidentiary concern without claiming a proven alteration.

Review two different seal records

Question: Package A has a broken seal with an authorized laboratory opening and resealing event documented. Package B has a broken seal but no recorded event. What should the reviewer do?
1. Treat the documented laboratory event for A as traceable, while checking the replacement seal record under policy.
2. Flag B as an unexplained integrity discrepancy and preserve the original log.
3. Check transfer receipts and authorized examination records before drawing a conclusion about cause or effect.
Answer: B requires immediate discrepancy review; the log alone does not prove tampering.
Check: A complete, contemporaneous record supports traceability; it does not replace applicable legal or laboratory review.

Common misconceptions

- Collecting before recording location can remove useful scene context.
- A label alone is not a complete record of every transfer.
- A broken or incomplete seal entry is not by itself proof of tampering.
- Guidance must be applied with local law, agency policy, safety, and laboratory requirements.

Practice patterns

- For scene questions, preserve context and relationships before collection unless an urgent
- risk requires protection.
- For custody questions, trace identifier, condition, package, seal, transfer, and authorized
- opening records.
- For a broken-seal scenario, distinguish an unexplained gap from proof of tampering or a legal
- conclusion.

Official scope references

Official scope: Enhanced Tables of Specifications for the Licensure Examination for Criminologists — Professional Regulation Commission; Professional Regulatory Board of Criminology — https://www.prc.gov.ph/sites/default/files/2024-02%20Published%20%281%29%20%281%29.pdf

Instructional references

Instructional reference: Crime Scene Investigation: A Guide for Law Enforcement — National Institute of Justice / National Forensic Science Technology Center — https://nij.ojp.gov/library/publications/crime-scene-investigation-guide-law-enforcement
Instructional reference: Crime Scene Investigation: Guides for Law Enforcement — National Institute of Justice — https://nij.ojp.gov/topics/articles/crime-scene-investigation-guides-law-enforcement
Instructional reference: Collecting DNA Evidence at Property Crime Scenes: Chain of Custody — National Institute of Justice, U.S. Department of Justice — https://nij.ojp.gov/nij-hosted-online-training-courses/collecting-dna-evidence-at-property-crime-scenes/evidence-collection/chain-custody

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